

Rob Spies

Director, Strategic Resource Group | THL Partners | 10:30 AM CDT | Zoom (30 min)

WHO HE IS

Rob leads the **Strategic Resource Group** at Thomas H. Lee Partners (THL) — a Boston-based middle market PE firm. His role is operating-partner territory: he works alongside portfolio company management teams on growth acceleration, GTM strategy, and capability deployment. At THL since 2014 (VP → Principal → Director). Prior: Vistaprint (Product Marketing), Monitor Group (Management Consulting). **He's not evaluating Improving as a vendor for THL — he's thinking about which portfolio company needs you.**

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HOW THIS CAME TOGETHER

Bob Freeburg (Director, THL — 10+ year Improving relationship) made the intro on May 18, five weeks into his own new role at THL. Bob told Rob: *"I've worked with David's teams on multiple engagements over the last 10 years and trust their capabilities."* He added Rob is *"close to the company we discussed"* — that company is **Odessa** (see below).

Rob replied same-day: *"Looking forward to learning more about your group"* and immediately CC'd Yolanda Solana to schedule. This is a **warm, intentional intro** — not a courtesy connection.

THE REAL AGENDA: ODESSA

On May 13, Bob called David — his *first call* after joining THL — specifically about a portfolio company called **Odessa**. Key facts from that conversation:

What Odessa is: Leasing tech and professional services platform serving banking/financial services. THL has owned it for 5 years.

The problem: Near-zero margins, THL's president called it "a black box after five years." Bob's hypothesis: sales is saying yes to everything and professional services can't deliver. Classic scope/margin compression.

Scale: ~700–800 people in professional services delivery, based in **Bangalore, India**. Potential Bangalore acquisition also in the works.

Why Improving fits: India presence (Improving has Bangalore capacity — ~840km from Pune, but Bob said "the fact that you have an India presence is significant"). Improving's due diligence capability (Trinity Hunt background) and AI practice are directly relevant.

Where things stood May 13: Bob was meeting the lead THL investor the next day to make the case. He said he'd circle back. The Rob intro four days later is almost certainly the follow-through.

Bottom line: Rob is "close to" Odessa. This call is likely the bridge between Bob's internal advocacy and a real engagement conversation.

CONVERSATION THREADS

- 1. Open on Odessa directly.** "Bob mentioned he'd talked to you about a specific company — I want to make sure we're talking about the right thing. Is this about Odessa?" Don't dance around it. Bob clearly briefed him.
- 2. The margin/delivery problem.** If confirmed: "Our read is this is a scope discipline and delivery capacity issue — is that aligned with what you're seeing?" Show you understand the problem, not just the opportunity.
- 3. India presence.** Improving has Bangalore capacity. Bob flagged this as significant. Lead with it if the Bangalore delivery org comes up.

4. How SRG engages partners. "Do you bring partners in directly, or do you introduce to the portfolio company team?" You need to know if Rob is the decision-maker or the connector.

5. Broader THL portfolio. If Odessa isn't the only thread: "What other portfolio companies are you looking at for tech or AI capability gaps?" Bob joined THL specifically to deploy AI across 50 companies — there's a pipeline here.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

Rob is extremely busy (Bob flagged this, Rob confirmed it by delegating scheduling to Yolanda immediately). Keep it tight, let him drive, don't oversell. If he gets specific about Odessa's problems, he's bought in — pivot to capability and next steps. If he stays high-level, ask for the introduction to the Odessa team directly.

ONE ASK

Walk out with a named next step: either an intro to the Odessa leadership team, or a follow-up scoping call with Rob. If neither surfaces: *"What would need to be true for this to move forward?"*

Intro via Bob Freeburg (Director, THL Partners) | May 18, 2026 | Related: Plaud 2026-05-13 — Bob Freeburg / Odessa Underperformance | Confidential — Improving